Swish Teardown (Did my assignment)

By Aastha Gulati · #buildinginpublic

Here's the thing.

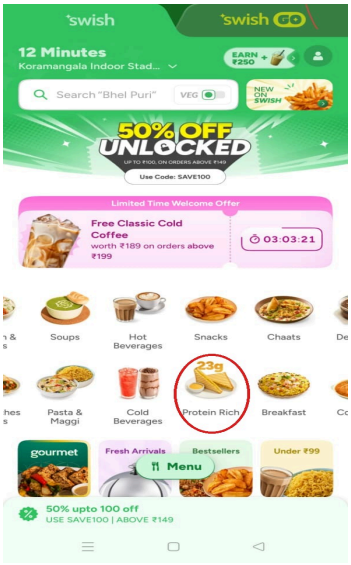
I'm the User Persona that SWISH is targeting. Bangalore, Gen Z, working in corporate, actually gives a shit about protein, orders food most lunches and most late nights. Repeat customer written all over me.

And every single time I open the Swish app, I spend 15 seconds hunting for the one section I actually came for. Usually I give up and order whatever was loudest on screen. That's not a design nitpick. That's a drop-off story. Three things are broken with how Swish handles the Protein section, in order of damage:

1. It's buried.

Protein Rich sits in Row 2, position 4. I have to side-scroll past Sandwiches & Rolls, Pasta & Maggi, and Cold Beverages before I even see it. By then I've already lost interest.

Fix: Pin a "Protein Picks" collection to the top of the home at Breakfast (7-9), lunch (12-3) and dinner (7-10). Don't make me hunt for the thing I came for.



2. The tile fades into itself.

A muted yellow sandwich on a cream background with a yellow "23g" badge that disappears into the same tile. Snacks and Chaats pop. Protein Rich doesn't. If I'm scrolling fast, I miss it entirely.

Fix: Give the tile actual contrast. Darker background, badge in red or green so the "23g" actually screams "hey, this is what you came for."

3. Protein grams only show after I tap into the dish. Same for calories.

The whole point of the Protein Rich section is... protein. But the home listing shows the dish name and the image, nothing about the macros. Someone looking for 25g+ or trying to stay under 500 cal has to tap into every single thing to find out. That's annoying.

Fix: Put the macro quick-view ON the dish card. "Paneer Bowl, 28g protein, 420 cal." One line. Removes a step. Builds trust. Tells the user you actually get what they came for.

Why this is a drop-off driver, not a design nitpick: Health-focused users leave with lower-quality orders than they came for, or close the app and order from somewhere else. Over time I start to associate Swish with "whatever was easy" instead of "the place I go to actually eat well." That's retention, not styling. Also, this is a category Swiggy and Zomato don't lean into with real specificity. If Swish nails it, they own it.

This is the biggest opportunity I spotted. It's also the most personal.

But the Protein thing isn't the only story.

I pulled Swish's 1-star Play Store reviews from the last 3 months and the complaints have a pattern. Six bugs keep showing up across different users. In rough order of how much they cost:

1. They cancel your order without asking. Sometimes after an hour.

Fix: Give me 5 minutes max to decide the fate of my order, not 60. Pop up "wait longer, swap kitchen, or instant refund." Don't just vanish on me.

From: Kiran K + Shilpa Seksaria

2. Payment goes through. Food doesn't. Refund doesn't come.

Fix: Auto-fire the refund the second the order fails. 30 seconds flat. And stop releasing money to the restaurant before I've actually said "yeah I got it."

From: madhur + Shilpa

3. App literally lies. Says "Delivered" when nothing came.

Fix: Delivery agent doesn't get to mark delivered. I do, with an OTP at the door. Also, confirm my pin on a map BEFORE the order goes out, not after it fails and nobody can find my building.

From: madhur + Kiran

4. Promised freebies just disappear. And then support says "you never ordered that."

This one's wild. PianoPianist literally called Swish a FRAUD company over a Rs 150 cold coffee that never showed up. Twice.

Fix: Freebies are real items with real SKUs. They go through the same dispatch check as paid stuff. Miss one? Credit me 2x the value, immediately, in-app. No fighting required.

From: PianoPianist

5. Customer support basically doesn't exist.

3 out of 6 bad reviews mention it. This isn't one bug, this is the thing that turns every other bug into a 1-star.

Fix: For a 10-min app, support has to move at the speed of the food. 2-min WhatsApp SLA. In-app "what went wrong" with instant-fix buttons for the top 5 problems. Humans only when you genuinely need one.

6. Half the categories don't show "View dish details."

Sandwiches & Rolls, Biryani, Rice Bowls... nope. The others do. It's inconsistent and feels like someone shipped half the feature and forgot the rest.

Fix: Just add it everywhere. Should be an afternoon's work.

From: me, scrolling through

If you fix #5 first, the business impact of the others shrinks dramatically. Right now the recovery experience is slower than the delivery itself. In a 10-min category, that's the real problem.

Alright, enough about what's broken.

Here are four things that aren't in Swish today that would actually move the needle. These are ideas, not bugs.

1. "Your usuals" row at the top.

If I've ordered before, show me my 3 most-ordered items first thing. Done. Zomato does this. DoorDash does this. It's the simplest personalization that exists and it cuts decision time by like 60%.

2. "What people are ordering right now in your area."

A strip showing live-ish trending orders in your 1km radius. Two things it does: kills "ugh I don't know what to eat" paralysis + creates urgency ("200 people ordered this in the last hour, must be good"). Especially sharp for midnight cravings between 12-2 AM when I'm hungry but have zero decision-making energy left.

3. Meal Clock. The home shifts based on time of day AND calorie behavior.

Two layers stacked:

Time layer: Breakfast stuff in the morning. Mid-weight at lunch. Something different at night.

Calorie-by-user-type layer: If my order history says I eat healthy, Swish should push calorie-dense options during the day (I need the energy, I'm at my desk, I probably hit the gym) and lighter stuff at night (digestion, winding down, lighter calories before sleep). If I'm an 11 PM pizza person, Swish should lean the other way for me, indulgent-friendly options when I'm looking for them.

Why this works for Swish specifically: 10-min delivery is more impulse-driven and more context-sensitive than 45-min delivery. Zomato does a shallow version of time-based rotation. Swish could go way deeper by layering hour + calories + user history on top. Nobody's doing this well in India right now.

4. "What are you craving?" mood pills.

A horizontal pill strip near the top: *Light & comforting, Protein rich, Full meal, Something sweet, Something spicy.* One tap filters the home.

Important: don't ship this as a modal that blocks the app. That's friction, that's drop-off. Ship it as persistent pills in a row. User ignores them or taps them, no commitment either way.

Why this is different from the category grid: categories organized by food TYPE (chaats, sandwiches). Mood pills organized by INTENT (what vibe am I in). I usually know my mood before I know the dish. Different cuts of the same data.

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